

WC2026 Friends Pool - Rules

Everyone drafts teams from three odds-tiered pots. Your teams earn (and lose) points across the whole tournament from the categories below. Most points at the end wins. The pool leans into chaos - plenty of ways to score are deliberately perverse, so read carefully.

Goals & shots

Event	Points
Open-play goal	+0.5 each
Free-kick goal	doubles the OPPONENT team's points for that game (scores nothing for you)
Penalty scored - not a shootout	-1.5 each
Penalty scored - in a shootout	-0.5 each
Goal ruled out by VAR	-1 each
0 shots on target in a game	+4
Goal scored OR conceded in the 23rd or 67th minute	+4 (max +4 per game, even if you own both teams)
Each game your team fails to score (clean sheet against you)	-1 (own both teams & it's 0-0 = 0; extra time excluded)
Prime number of total goals in the tournament (excludes shootout goals)	-3

A free-kick goal still counts toward your team's total-goals tally (so it can still trigger the prime -3 and the fewest-goals award) - it just earns you nothing directly.

The 90'+ rule

- A goal from 90:00 onwards - the 90th minute and ALL of its injury/stoppage time (recorded as 90 or 90+X) - multiplies that team's IN-GAME points for that game by -1 - i.e. the goals, the 23'/67' bonus, the 0-shots-on-target bonus, the clean-sheet, and the red-card dice from that game.
- 90:00 ONWARDS, INJURY TIME ONLY - this is NOT extra time. A goal in extra time (91-120, e.g. 105 or 120) does NOT count for this rule.
- It hits ONLY that game's in-game total. It does NOT touch the tournament-long ranked prizes (quickest goal, quickest yellow, fastest sub, fastest own goal, youngest/oldest scorer, longest/shortest name, fewest goals, fewest cards) or the prime-goals penalty - those are never flipped.
- They STACK as repeated x -1, so an ODD number of 90:00+ goals flips the game and an EVEN number cancels back. 1 or 3 such goals = flipped; 2 or 4 = unchanged. Worked example: say a team's in-game total for the match is +6. One 90:00+ goal makes it -6; a second cancels it back to +6; a THIRD flips it again to -6.
- In-game points flip in ANY game (win or lose).
- Progression points only flip in your ELIMINATION game. Winning teams bank no progression at that moment, so a champion's Winner points are always safe - but a runner-up who scores a 90'+ goal in the final they lose flips their +8 to -8.

Red card - roll the dice

- When one of your teams gets a red card, roll a single d6.
- Odd roll -> you GAIN (roll / 2) points: 1 = +0.5, 3 = +1.5, 5 = +2.5
- Even roll -> you LOSE (roll / 2) points: 2 = -1, 4 = -2, 6 = -3

- No rounding - half-points stand.

Ranked categories

Each category ranks the top 6 teams across the WHOLE tournament, and the points go to their owners. Reward categories pay 10 / 8 / 5 / 3 / 2 / 1 to the six best; deduction categories take the same off (-10 / -8 / -5 / -3 / -2 / -1) for topping a list you do NOT want to top.

Type	Points (top 6)	Categories
Reward	10 / 8 / 5 / 3 / 2 / 1	Quickest Goal · Youngest Goalscorer · Fastest Substitute · Fastest Own Goal · Quickest Yellow Card · Longest-Named Goalscorer
Deduction	-10 / -8 / -5 / -3 / -2 / -1	Oldest Goalscorer · Shortest-Named Goalscorer

- Each person can only have ONE team qualify per category - their single best-scoring team in it. If two of your teams would both place, only the higher one counts; the other is skipped and that prize rolls down to the next DISTINCT owner.
- Worked example: own the team with the tournament's 2nd-quickest goal and you score +8 in Quickest Goal. Own the team with the OLDEST goalscorer and you lose -10 in the Oldest Goalscorer deduction.
- Ties split the points between the tied owners (owning several tied teams = a bigger share).
- Tiebreak: the most recent occurrence ranks higher.
- Data source priority: official FIFA, else BBC, else ITV.

Flat awards

- Fewest Goals (whole tournament): +7 to the single team with fewest (tie-split between owners).
- Fewest Cards (whole tournament): +7 to the single team with fewest (tie-split between owners).

Tournament progression

Points for how far each team gets - scored in the round it's KNOCKED OUT (the winner is never knocked out).

Knocked out in...	R32	R16	QF	SF	Final (runner-up)	Won it
Points	+1	+2	+3	+5	+8	+10

- 3rd-place playoff WINNER: -5 overall (NOT the SF +5) - winning the consolation game is punished, so finishing 3rd is worse than 4th.
- 4th place (loses the 3rd-place playoff): keeps the SF +5.

Early-exit bonus

A reward for drafting teams that all crash out early. Players are ranked by when their LAST surviving team is knocked out - the sooner all three of your teams are gone, the more you score.

1st all-out	2nd	3rd or 4th	5th or 6th	7th or 8th	9th-16th
5	4	3	2	1	0

- Your exit is set by your FURTHEST team - you're only 'out' once all three are eliminated.

- It's about WHEN you're confirmed out, not just the stage. A team mathematically eliminated earlier in its group (say after game 5) ranks ahead of one that isn't confirmed out until a later game - you don't wait for the group to finish.
- Players confirmed out at the SAME time tie, and split the summed points for the positions they fill. Example: if three players' last teams are all confirmed out together, they take positions 1-3 and split $5 + 4 + 3 = 12$, i.e. 4 points each.
- A team that wins the tournament never goes out, so its owner finishes last here (0).

The draft - pots

16 players. Each player drafts THREE teams - one from each pot - so every squad gets a strong team, a mid team and a long shot (16 players x 3 = the full 48). The pots are seeded by each team's "to reach the quarter-finals" odds: Pot 1 is the 16 strongest, Pot 3 the 16 longest shots.

Pot 1 - strongest	Pot 2 - middle	Pot 3 - long shots
Spain	Japan	Australia
France	Uruguay	Ghana
England	Croatia	South Africa
Portugal	Ecuador	Panama
Argentina	Senegal	DR Congo
Brazil	Austria	Saudi Arabia
Germany	Ivory Coast	Tunisia
Netherlands	Canada	Uzbekistan
Norway	Sweden	New Zealand
Belgium	Paraguay	Cape Verde
Colombia	Scotland	Jordan
Morocco	South Korea	Iraq
Mexico	Egypt	Haiti
USA	Algeria	Qatar
Switzerland	Czechia	Curaçao
Turkey	Bosnia & Herzegovina	Iran

Prizes & forfeits

- 1st place: a shirt of any sports team of their choice, paid for by everyone else (capped at £150).
- Last place: must buy SEVEN other players (their choice) dessert - in person, and within 3 months of the final.
- The dice gift: once the final standings are locked, roll a 16-sided die twice. The player who finished in the FIRST position rolled buys the player who finished in the SECOND a £20 gift - e.g. a roll of 4 then 7 means whoever finished 4th has to buy whoever finished 7th. Re-roll if the same position comes up twice.

Rules locked from the conversation of June 2026. If anything here doesn't match what you expected, flag it before the draft.